- **Chronic stress**.
- **Certain drugs**. Birth control pills may increase blood pressure.
- **Caffeine**. Some people, who are sensitive to caffeine may experience an increase in blood pressure.

Principles of diet

Low calorie, low fat, low sodium diet with normal protein is prescribed.

Energy

Calorie restriction to aid weight loss is recommended for overweight and obese individuals, which significantly reduces the blood pressure and LDL cholesterol levels. Weight loss along with drug therapy decreases the dose or number of drugs necessary to control blood pressure.

Protein: Adequate intake of 50- 60 g protein is necessary to maintain optimal nutrition.

Fats: Fat intake with emphasis on low saturated and high PUFA & MUFA is recommended to facilitate weight control and decrease the risk of CVD.

Carbohydrate: Complex carbohydrate as whole grain helps to manage high blood pressure.

Sodium: In sodium sensitive people, restricting sodium to 2-g is sufficient.

In severe cases of hypertension, a moderate 1-g sodium level may be indicated.

How to cut salt intake

Strategies to cut salt intake include:

- Select fresh, unprocessed foods.
- Cook with little or no added salt avoid pickles and salted fried.
- Prepare foods with sodium-free spices such as basil, bay leaves, curry leaves, garlic, ginger, mint, pepper, lemon juice, vinegar in place of some or all of the salt to add flavour .
- Read labels for sodium to select low-salt or salt-free products when available.
- Avoid preservatives like monosodium glutamate, soya sauce, ketchups, Cheese, and salted butter.
- Canned and instant soups.
- Gelatin, cakes, biscuit and candies.

DO YOU KNOW?

2.4g of sodium is approximately equivalent to 6 g sodium chloride or table salt.

Other minerals

Minerals like calcium and magnesium are found to be beneficial in controlling blood pressure, e.g. Low fat dairy products, green leafy vegetables and nuts. Increasing the potassium to replace the loss with diuretics. Most of the fruits and vegetables are rich in potassium.

Exercise

Moderate physical activity (30-45 minutes of brisk walking) is recommended as weight loss is associated with reduced blood pressure values.

1.7 Diet in Diabetes Mellitus

Diabetes mellitus is a group of metabolic diseases characterised by high blood glucose resulting from defects in insulin secretion, insulin action or both.

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